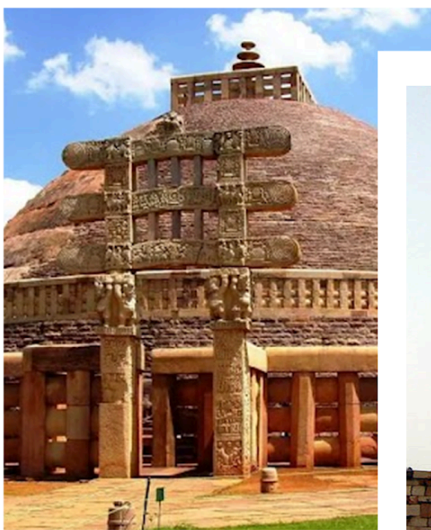


General Knowledge

Ancient History

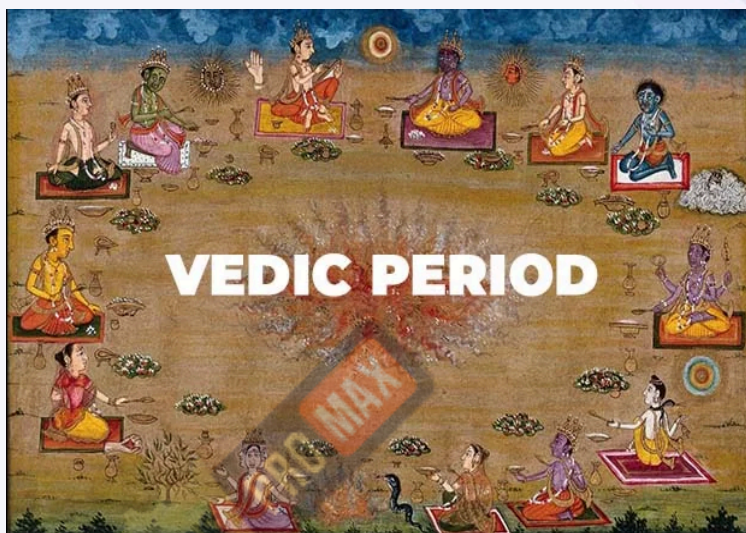
STUDY NOTES

Early Vedic Period



INTRODUCTION

- Following the decline of the **Indus Valley Civilization**, which flourished around **2600 BCE to 1900 BCE**, a new cultural era began in the Indian subcontinent.
- This period is marked by the arrival of the Aryans. In the context of ancient history, the **Aryans were the people who spoke Indo-Iranian languages** and migrated to the Indian subcontinent around **1500 BCE**.
- The first person to refer to the Aryans as a distinct race was the **German scholar Max Muller**.



Key sources of information about the Aryans

- The **Rigveda** is **one of the oldest known texts** in the world. It was composed in Vedic Sanskrit around 1500-1000 BCE. It consists of hymns dedicated to various deities and provides insights into early Vedic society, culture, and religion.
- The **Avesta(found in Iran)** is the primary collection of religious texts of Zoroastrianism, composed in the Avestan language. it is closely related to the Vedic Aryans.
- The **Mitanni Inscriptions(found in Siria)** written in Hurrian and Akkadian, contain references to Vedic deities such as Indra, Varuna, and Mitra, indicating cultural and religious connections with the Vedic Aryans.
- The **Kassites Inscriptions(found in Iraq)** written in Akkadian, also show evidence of Indo-Iranian influence, particularly in the names of their kings and deities.

the term "Arya" (आर्य) is derived from the Sanskrit word meaning "noble" or "honorable." who adhered to the cultural and social norms of the Vedic society,

Origins of Aryans and their Entry into India

The **most widely accepted** theory is that the Aryans originated from the **steppes of Central Asia**, particularly around the region of modern-day Kazakhstan and southern Russia. Other theories suggest origins in regions like the Eastern Alps, the Danube Valley, and even the Arctic. The Aryans are believed to have entered India around 1500 BCE. They migrated through the northwestern passes, such as the **Khyber Pass**, and settled in the region known

as the **Sapta Sindhu (land of seven rivers)**, which includes parts of modern-day Punjab and Haryana.

The Aryans' dominance was due to superior military technology, effective warfare strategies, a well-organized social structure, cultural assimilation, and improved agricultural practices, which collectively enabled them to establish a strong presence in ancient India.

Theory	Scholar(s)
Central Asia	Max Müller
Southern Russia	Nehring, Gordon Childe
Northern Polar Region	Bal Gangadhar Tilak

Vedic culture is divided into two part

- **Early Vedic Period (Rigvedic Period)**
- **Later Vedic Period**

EARLY VEDIC PERIOD

The Early Vedic Period, also known as the **Rigvedic Period**, spans from approximately 1500 BCE to 1000 BCE. This era is primarily documented in the Rigveda, one of the oldest sacred texts.

- The Early Vedic Period lasted from approximately **1500 BCE to 1000 BCE**.
- The **Rigveda** is the main source documenting this era, consisting of hymns and rituals.
- The society was organized into tribes led by a Rajan (tribal chief), with assemblies like **Sabha** and **Samiti**.
- The economy was primarily **pastoral**, focusing on cattle rearing, with limited agricultural practices.
- The society was concentrated in the **Sapta-Sindhu** region, encompassing the Indus and its tributaries.
- Worship centered around nature deities such as **Indra**, **Agni**, and **Varuna**, with yajnas (sacrifices) being common.

- **Vedic Sanskrit** was used in hymns, indicating a rich oral tradition before being written down.
- A **patriarchal system** existed, with early signs of a varna system (division of society into four categories).
- Women enjoyed a relatively **respected position**, with some composing hymns in the Rigveda.

Brief Table About Early Vedic Period:

Aspect	Details
Time-Period	c. 1500 – 1000 BCE
Primary Source	Rigveda (oldest Veda, composed during this period)
Geographical Region	Sapta-Sindhu region (Land of Seven Rivers: Indus, Saraswati, and five tributaries – Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas, and Sutlej)
Political Structure	- Tribal society - Rajan (tribal chief) as the leader - Assemblies like Sabha and Samiti played advisory roles
Economic Structure	- Pastoral economy with a focus on cattle rearing (cows were highly prized) - Limited agriculture, primarily barley (yava) and wheat
Social Structure	- Patriarchal society - Society divided into tribes (Janas) - No rigid caste system, but early signs of the Varna system (Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, and Shudra)
Religion	- Nature worship (e.g., worship of natural elements like fire, wind, and rain) - Major deities included Indra (god of rain and war), Agni (god of fire), Varuna (god of cosmic order), and Soma (god of plants and an intoxicating drink)

Rituals and Sacrifices	- Yajna (sacrificial rituals) were common - Offerings made to gods through fire (Agni)
Society's Focus	- Focus on warrior virtues (Indra, the warrior god, was the most important) - Family was the basic unit of society
Language and Literature	- Vedic Sanskrit was the language of the hymns and rituals - Oral tradition: Rigveda was passed down orally before being written down
Key Occupations	- Cattle herding and animal husbandry were the main occupations - Some agriculture, hunting, and warfare
Key Weapons	- Use of chariots, bows and arrows, spears, and swords - Horses were an essential part of warfare
Women's Role	- Women had a respected place in society - Some women like Apala, Ghosha, and Lopamudra composed hymns in the Rigveda
Trade and Exchange	- Barter system was prevalent (mainly cattle and other goods) - Very little evidence of external trade
Cultural Practices	- Music and dance were part of religious rituals - Society enjoyed feasts and celebrations associated with religious ceremonies
Science and Knowledge	- Early knowledge of astronomy and medicine (herbs and prayers used for healing)

Areas Related to the early Vedic period:

Region	Present Day Region	Boundary within the Rivers
Aryavarta	Northern India (Indo-Gangetic Plain)	From the Himalayas to the Vindhya Range, between the Eastern Sea (Bay of Bengal) and Western Sea (Arabian Sea)
Brahmarshi Desh	Uttar Pradesh	Ganges and Yamuna rivers
Brahmavarta	Haryana and parts of Rajasthan	Sarasvati and Drishadvati rivers
Madhyadesha	Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh	Ganges, Yamuna, and their tributaries
Sapta Sindhu	Punjab	Indus (Sindhu) and its tributaries: Sutlej, Ravi, Chenab, Jhelum

Important Description included in Rigveda

- It tells about a total of **42 rivers** flowing in **North India**.
- The **Sindhu River** is mentioned most frequently in the Rigveda and referred to as Naditama (the most sacred river).
- The **Ganga river** is mentioned only once.
- The term "**dhanv**" is used to refer to the desert.
- The **Rigveda** mentions the Himalayan mountains and its peak, **Munjavat**, which was renowned for the **Soma**.

Archaeological evidence from the Rigvedic period

- Painted grey pottery
- 13-room house, **Bhagwanpura**(Haryana)
- Fortified settlements, Ropar, Sarai Hira

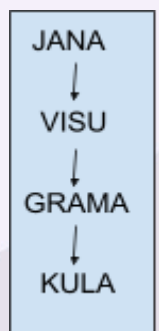
The Rigveda was included in the UNESCO Memory of the World Register in 2007, highlighting its significance as one of the earliest literary documents in human history.

- Bronze and iron tools, weapons, ornaments
- Animal bones (horses, cattle)
- Organized community living
- Researchers are exploring DNA evidence from ancient remains to understand the ancestry and migration patterns of the Vedic people.

Ancient Name	Modern Name
Kumbha	Khan or Kabul River
Suvastu	Swat
Krumu	Kurram
Gomal	Gomati
Vitasta	Jhelum
Ashkini	Chenab
Parushani	Ravi
Vipasa	Beas
Shutudri	Sutlej
Sadaneera	Gandak
Drishdwati	Ghaggar-Hakra
Marudvridha	Maru River

● Political Structure

The political structure of the Rigvedic period was primarily tribal and patriarchal.



- **Rajan (Tribal Chief):** The tribe, known as Jana, was led by a Rajan, who was supported by two assemblies, the Sabha and the Samiti.
- **Sabha and Samiti:** These assemblies played crucial roles in decision-making and governance.
- **Kula (Family):** The basic unit of political organization was the family, headed by the Kulapa.
- **Grama (Village):** Multiple families formed a village, led by a Gramini.
- **Visu (Group of Villages):** A group of villages formed a Visu, headed by a Vishayapati.

The **Sabha** was an **advisory council** consisting of elder members and noblemen of the tribe. It played a crucial role in judicial and administrative decisions, providing guidance to the Rajan (tribal chief) on various matters.

The **Samiti** was a broader assembly that included representatives from different clans, embodying a more democratic element within the tribal society. It had a significant role in the **election of the Rajan** and discussed community affairs such as wars, alliances, and welfare. The Samiti was **headed by the Rajan**.

- The **Dasharajnya War**, also known as the Battle of the Ten Kings, is mentioned in the **7th Mandala of the Rigveda**. It was fought between **King Sudas of the Bharatas** and a confederation of ten tribes near the **Parusni River** (modern Ravi River) in Punjab. The Bharatas emerged victorious, leading to the formation of the Kuru polity.

Society

- During the Rigvedic period, society was organized around the **concepts of Gotra**, which formed the basis for social organization.
- The **term Varna**, initially meant to **denote color**, later evolved to signify the classification of society into different groups.
- The **Purushsukta**, found in the **10th Mandala of the Rigveda**, mentions this division, marking the beginning of social stratification and differentiation within the society.
- **Patriarchy was predominant**, with family lineages traced through the male line, highlighting a patriarchal system.
- Education and knowledge transfer were **primarily oral**, relying on the oral transmission of hymns, rituals, and traditions from one generation to the next.
- This period laid the groundwork for a structured and hierarchical society, deeply rooted in Vedic traditions and customs.
- During the Rigvedic period, **women enjoyed a relatively liberal and respected position** in society.

- They participated in religious rituals, and intellectual pursuits, and even held positions of authority.
- Notable women such as **Apala, Lopamudra, and Vishwavara** are celebrated figures from this era.
- Apala is known for her hymns, Lopamudra for her wisdom and contribution to Vedic chants, and Vishwavara for her active participation in composing hymns.
- The Rigvedic Aryans were both **vegetarian and non-vegetarian**.
- People wore ornaments like **Karnshobhan (earrings), Kurir (head ornaments), and Jyochani (rings)**.

Economy

- The economy of the Rigvedic Aryans was **predominantly agricultural and pastoral**. Agriculture is extensively mentioned in the **4th Mandala of the Rigveda**, highlighting its importance with crops like barley and wheat being central.
 - Women who weave saree fabrics are called Siri.
 - They know about five seasons.
 - Terms such as Urvara (fertile land), Langal (plow), Karishu (manure), and Khilya (pasture) reflect the advanced agricultural practices of the time.

Religion

- Religion in the Early Vedic period was characterized by **polytheism and the worship of natural forces and deities**. The primary deities included Agni (fire), Indra (thunder and war), and Varuna (cosmic order). Religious practices centered around elaborate rituals and **sacrifices to appease these deities and ensure prosperity and protection**.

Type of God	Deities
Sky Gods	Surya (Sun God), Dyaus(Sky Father), Varuna (God of Cosmic Order and Water)
Space Gods	Indra (God of Thunder and War), Rudra (God of Storms), Vayu (God of Wind)
Earth Gods	Agni (God of Fire), Som (God of the Moon and plants), Prithvi (Earth Goddess)

Important Facts:

- ★ The Rigveda describes a **boat with a hundred oars**.
- ★ A student writes, "**I am a poet, my father is a physician, and my mother grinds the grain.**"
- ★ The slavery system was prevalent.
- ★ Varuna, the god of cosmic order, was called **Ritashya Gopa**.
- ★ Soma is mentioned extensively in the **9th Mandala**.
- ★ The terms **gavishta** and **gesu** were used in the context of battles.

